



Many doctors report that one of the most common questions when a baby is born is, understandably, **“Is everything alright?”** Here, we look at some concerns parents might face. These might be conditions that you’ve heard others talk about, or that you’ve had experience of, either in a previous pregnancy or through a family member or friend.

Issues at birth

Assessing your baby

As soon as your baby is born, her immediate well-being will be assessed. Then, over the following 48 hours, a staff pediatrician will do a series of checkups on your baby for complications or problems. Many of the conditions in this section, including ones such as cleft lip, tongue-tie, and hernia, will be picked up during these checkups (see p.246)—or may even have been picked up during pregnancy—and, if necessary, treatment can begin immediately. Regularly scheduled office visits to the pediatrician over the next weeks and months provide a means of ensuring that all continues to be well, that your baby is growing, and that you are recovering well, too. As the weeks and months progress, you should begin to feel more secure about your role as parent, and you’ll see the proof that you’re doing a good job as your baby gains weight over time. If you have any questions as time passes, always ask the doctor. While some problems are picked up on quickly, others may become apparent only after a period of time, which is why your baby’s development is followed closely in these early months.

Trust your instincts

You are the person most closely attuned to your baby’s well-being, so if you think something might be wrong,

even if you’re worried you might be imagining things, raise it with the doctor. Concerns about newborns are always taken seriously, and no one will think you are overly anxious or overly cautious.

When a problem is found

Finding out that your baby has a problem is naturally upsetting. If a concern was identified during pregnancy, you will have had some time to adjust and find out about possible treatment. If a problem is discovered after the birth, you will have questions and concerns. Many minor concerns are easily remedied. Some do require longer-term treatment and sometimes your baby may need surgery, but most problems can be either eliminated or improved. Finding out about a condition early on means that treatment is prompt and outcomes improve.

This section looks at a range of conditions that can affect newborns, some of which may be identified or suspected during pregnancy through ultrasounds or because of concerns about a baby’s growth, and many of which are detected in the days and weeks following the birth. The conditions range from those that are relatively common, such as jaundice and umbilical hernias, to those that are rare. In each case the implications for your baby are explained as well as the treatment and help available.